



▲ Golden sarcophagus

This outer coffin is ornately decorated—reflecting the status of its occupant. Henettawy was princess and priestess of the 21st Dynasty. She was also a singer—a woman of high status who served in the temple of the god Amun.

► Beauty and strength

Queen Nefertiti became an icon of beauty thanks to this bust. She played a key role in the cult of the sun god, Aten, and may have ruled in her own right after her husband's death.

men and women had rather distinct functions. Especially in Egypt's New Kingdom (but not exclusively), women were far more likely to be entertainers for the deities, while men served more managerial roles. One of the most important priestesses was "God's Hand," which was usually reserved for women of royal rank. They "stimulated" the (male) creator deity Amun. Women were also "sealers"—a position with economic responsibility—using incised seals to mark the closures of rooms or containers and guard against theft.

Many women who worked were able to do so because they left the daily responsibilities of running a household to other family members, or to servants. Some homes even had slaves—usually captured in war—to do the work, although slavery was uncommon in ancient Egypt.

Female pharaohs

Well back into the Old Kingdom, it was common for powerful queens to serve as regents for their underaged sons. Hatshepsut, Egypt's longest-reigning female pharaoh, came to power this way around 1478 BCE, sharing the crown with two-year-old Thutmose III. One of ancient Egypt's most successful rulers, she adopted the full titles and regalia of a pharaoh—even the false beard that many wore. Queens could also wield some power as pharaohs' wives. Today one of the most famous is Queen Nefertiti, who reigned alongside Akhenaten in the 14th century BCE, although she disappeared from the history books until the discovery of her bust renewed interest in her life. Her tomb has never been found.

